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WHAT THE BJP SAYS

The Changing Patterns of Its Discourse

Whether they support the BJP, oppose it or are politically neutral, most Indians already have a broad mental map of what they think the party stands for and what it communicates. Our perceptions are based on WhatsApp messages, Instagram posts, Facebook threads, newspaper headlines and Twitter wars. Whether we vote for the party because we think it stands for a strong Hindu cultural identity, for the idea of a New India or non-dynastic politics, or whether we believe it to be a divisive, fascist or exclusivist political force bent on reshaping India into a nativist Hindu nation, most of us have already made up our minds about the BJP.

The question is: how does the party communicate its ideas? Which ones does it privilege, and when? How does it convey these ideas to different audiences? Which ones does it prioritise or underplay, and at what times? How does it calibrate its messaging at different times in the political cycle?

For the first time, we have data spread across years to see what the BJP communicates. Most analyses of political communications so far have been based on impressionistic accounts or small survey samples. Technology now gives us the tools to see the BJP's political communications—both online and offline—in its entirety.

Introducing the Narad Index